

CAMBRIDGE HARKENER

CELEBRATING THE HERITAGE OF CAMBRIDGE, VERMONT

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April 2021

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Memories of a Special Day at the South Cambridge Community Club's Old Home Day

Helaine Hubbard Perkins (former Cambridge resident)

About 1937 (I was 6 yrs. old) Sen. George Aiken came to celebrate Old Home Day with us. There was a much talked about event at our house and everyone seemed very honored to have this important visitor in town. Old Home Day was held, in the summer, once a year, at the Community Club House in South Cambridge. It featured an outdoor receiving line for the Senator, a lovely home cooked meal. Entertainment was usually provided by the youth of the various families. There was round and contra dancing in the evening.

I stood in line a very long time in order to shake Sen. Aiken's hand. Other children came and asked me to play but I refused and stayed in line. After what seemed ages, it came my turn to shake his hand. He bent over and said to me:

"Why did you wait in line so long to shake my hand?"

I responded:

"Because my father told me you were a very good man for Vermont farmers."

"Is your father a Vermont farmer?" he asked. "Yes." I replied.

Now, after nearly seven decades, I can still see his reaction to my comments.

He stood up, threw back his head, his tuft of white hair blowing in the wind, and laughed as hard as anyone I ever heard laugh. Then he patted me on top of the head.

I remember studying his reaction thoughtfully. I didn't think I had said anything funny, at all.

Then and there, I decided grownups sure are strange! I solemnly walked away.



Early History of Cambridge

by Ida Morgan Anderson

Beginning in 1935, Ida Morgan Anderson began serializing a column on the History of Cambridge in the *Cambridge Town Crier*. Many of our readers may remember the series of 27 Installments. The Harkener continues publishing the installments for a new audience on the assumption that the copyright (if it ever existed) has long since expired. We hope you will enjoy these "blasts from the past."

Installment Ten

The ability of the settlers to give quaint unforgettable names to different parts of the town, seizing upon some peculiarity with a kind of grim humor, was nothing less than genius. There was "North Bend," now North Cambridge, "The Territory" which included the road between Jeffersonville and east Fletcher, "Pleasant Valley", "Lost Nation", "Number 'leven", "Smugglers' Notch", and "Pumpkin Harbor", so named because one year during a fall freshet, a great quantity of pumpkins came down the Lamoille river and were left on the meadow of the Merritt Morgan farm.

A part of the adjoining town of Fletcher was always called "Fletcher Leg" and a village in Fairfield was known the country over as "Puddle Dock", another town had a location with the dubious name of "no God Hollow".

Cambridge was prosperous from the start and afforded many business opportunities. One of the most outstanding examples was that of John Warner who came on foot from Brookfield, Mass., in 1801. He carried all his extra clothing in his hand, and had so little money, that in spite of the most rigid economy, he had to stop on the way and work for a month to earn enough to finish his journey. He arrived here with thirty-five cents in his pocket. He hired out for two years, to Nathaniel Reed as a journeyman currier. Then he went into business for himself, and not long after, in true story book fashion, married the daughter of his employer, Miss Sally Reed. He bought the farm now owned by Harold Crane, and built a large Colonial brick house and a brick tannery near. Only three of their seven children lived to grow up, and the sons, Harrison and Chauncey, developing a tendency to tuberculosis, went to sea on a whaling voyage and rounded Cape Horn.

They returned from the voyage with



The Tannery Today

health firmly established, and were made partners in their father's business.

As they increased their holdings and added farm to farm, they decided to give up tanning and give all their attention to farming, and the raising of cattle and mules. So the interior of the tannery was altered into its present form and made into a house for a tenant. For a time, the territory road was given up to mule raising and was forever spoken of as "the mule pasture". In recent years this farm has been occupied by Ira Keith. Always a friend of the poor and needy, the day of John Warner's death was a day of universal mourning.

Harrison married Rebecca Wilson and lived on a farm of 500 acres near the Jeffersonville bridge with a mountain pasture of 1100 acres. They had no children. Chauncey remained on the home farm and never married. In addition to his own large property, he received a fortune from his father and another at the death of his brother. About 1881 he gave the town of St. Albans \$25,000 toward founding the Warner Home for Little Wanderers. In 1883 he purchased the large house and grounds of E.A. Smith for a free hospital. Five farms in Cambridge were given to endow the home and hospital. He died in 1899. Miss Sarah Phillips was his gracious and dignified house keeper until his death.

The building of John Warner's house and tannery brings out an interesting bit of local history, Jacob P. Colman, a personal friend of Mr. Warner, built a brick kiln and made and burned the bricks right on the spot where they were to be used. When the brick house on the Levi Atwood farm was built, it was Mr. Colman who went right there and made and burned the bricks. Mr. Colman was a graduate of Dartmouth College and came here from Newburyport, Mass., and settled on the "territory road". When roads were passable, Mrs. Colman used to go on horseback to Fairfield to attend church, and while there often helped care for the baby who afterwards became President Arthur.

A little way beyond the Newell Hawley farm, at the "Harbour", on the road to Fletcher there used to be another tannery, but it was given up years ago and finally torn down. It was owned by Jerman Safford.

Every town in the county had a starch factory. At Fairfax Falls was a woolen mill which later, under the management of Mr. Gant of Boston and Wayland Shepardson of Fairfax, became a flourishing concern.

There was also a brick gristmill and a store. Fairfax also had a pottery where S.H. and G.W. Farrar made all kinds of stoneware in brown, or in gray with deep blue decorations. Many of their jars and jugs are still in use.

*The Cambridge Historical Society's April Meeting
Wednesday, April 14, 2021
7:00 pm*

For the first time, CHS will be presenting a virtual program. This will be a test to determine the interest in attending a virtual event until we can again meet to enjoy each others' company and the refreshments provided by Diancy Boyden, among others.

The History of Cambridge Churches
Beth Cole

Churches and religion were an important part of the life of the early settlers beginning in the 1700s. This is a walk through the history of those churches.

Zoom Meeting Information

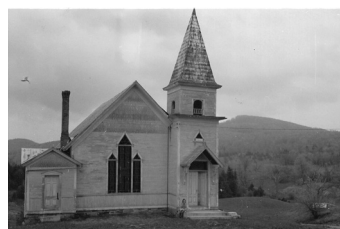
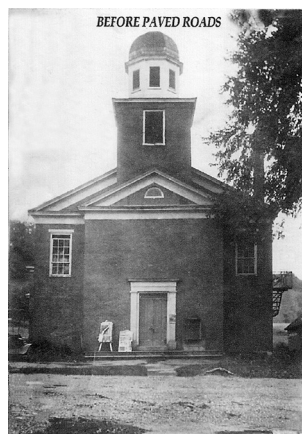
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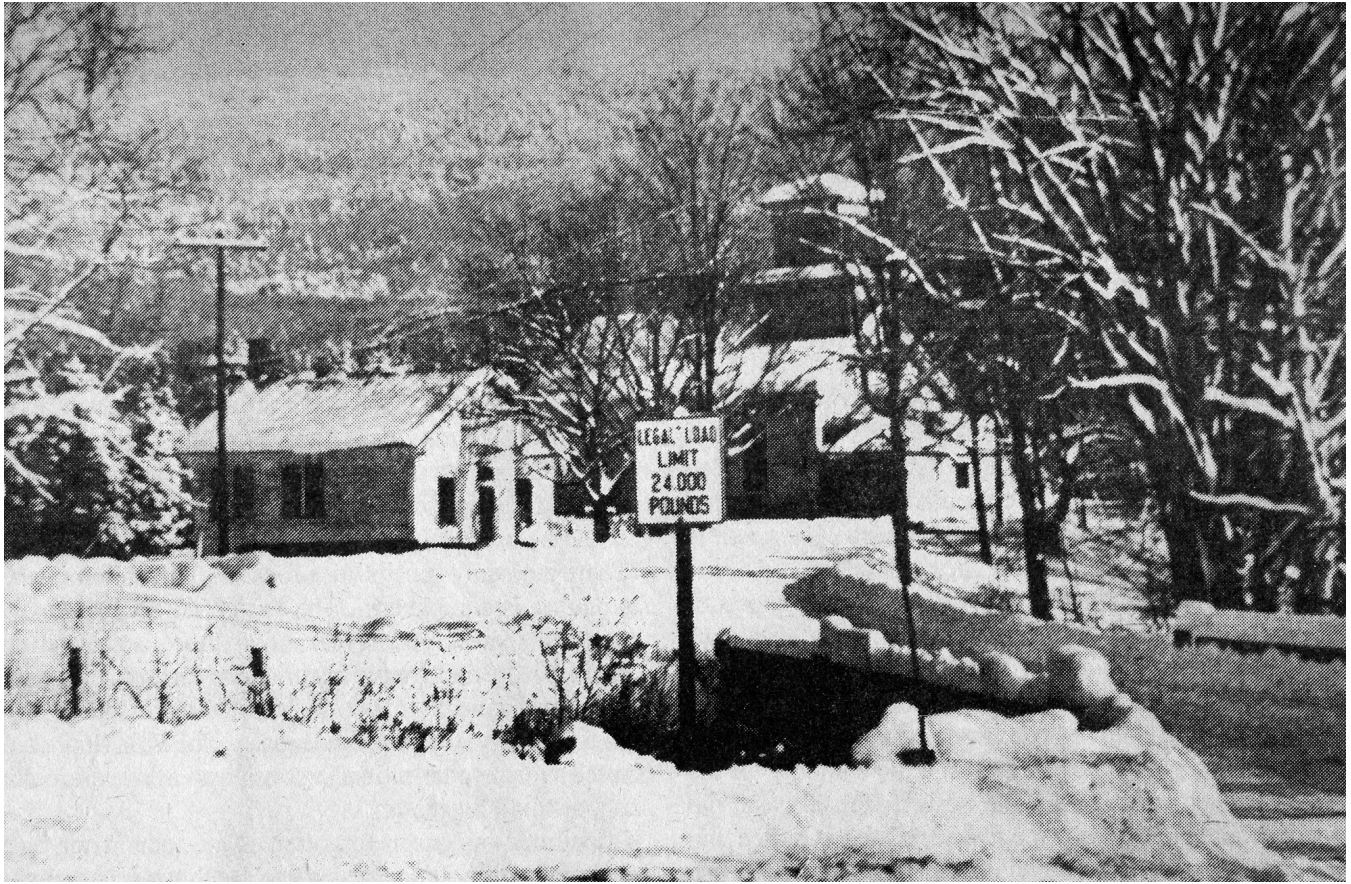
Dial by your location
+1 646 558 8656 US (New York)

Meeting ID: 833 5227 3992
Passcode: 179123

If you have question about how to access a Zoom meeting feel free to contact Georgeana Little at (802) 335-2002 or rgtle@stoweaccess.com. This will be an illustrated program, so joining by phone may not be optimal.

Can you identify each of these 7 churches?





A view of South Cambridge

South Cambridge School on the left with the South Cambridge Community Club Hall to its right. The Community House is now Martell's Red Fox. It has had many lives since this photo was taken. The Lamplough bridge is in the foreground.

Membership Application/Renewal

Please complete this form and mail to: Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464-0016
or email: rgtle@stowweaccess.com

☐ New

☐ Renewal

Name _____

Address _____
Number Street Town State Zip

Phone _____ E-Mail _____

Membership Category

☐ Individual \$15.00

☐ Family \$25.00

☐ Business \$25.00

Please consider becoming a:

☐ Patron \$500.00

☐ Benefactor \$1,000.00+

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

If you have suggestions about program topics or have some great ideas for fundraisers,
please let us know by listing your ideas below.

Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464



We do not have an article by Jennifer Bartlau for this issue. I'm sure many are disappointed. However, Jen will return with a new story about our ancestors buried in the Cambridge cemeteries. We have included a story sent to us by Helaine Perkins with a photo of the South Cambridge Community Club Hall. Also, a photo of South Cambridge from our archives.

In future, we hope to add a mystery photo to each issue of the Harkener. CHS has a lot of these photos so the help of our membership in identifying them will be much appreciated.

We have also again included a membership application. We have received many renewals and some new memberships since the last edition. If you have already renewed, or are a Life Member, feel free to pass on the application, and a personal recommendation, to others - and
Thank You.

This Newsletter is one of the perks of membership, so to continue receiving The Harkener
renew your membership, and THANK YOU.